

“Ergativity, properly aligned” – And the case of SHIPIBO

This is the reply to two¹ of three reviewers of “*Ergativity, properly aligned*.” Brandolini’s ‘Law’ (cf. Husser 2025) even governs the reviewing of papers, as it seems. It states that refuting false information requires an order of magnitude more effort than producing it. In scientific issues, an established consensus acts as the low-energy “default,” while the correction requires an enormous expenditure of energy. Apparently, I have not yet managed to achieve a strong enough magnitude to convince reviewers that ergative languages are wrongly portrayed as syntactically strange.

The paper was submitted without success to a well-renowned linguistics journal (impact factor 0.8 to 1.11, cite score of 3.4, SJR ranking Q1/Q2). If I were a young linguist trying to earn recognition, I would feel that I hadn’t been treated fairly. As a retired professor, I do not find this rejection unusual. Perhaps one day, AI will figure out that an old geezer wasn’t all that wrong in his work.

Of the two reviews I received, one is particularly informative (Review 2) and well-written, whilst the other one (Review 1) strikes me as unintentionally comical, yet intentionally condescending. It clearly violates Brandolini’s law as a review. Experience has shown me that when reviewers are in a hurry and don’t like a result, they tend to justify their negative judgment by emphasizing that the idea presented is *outdated*, the data is *not new*, the methodology is *flawed*, or that there are languages that *don’t fit* the concept. This is Review 1. It consists of thirty-one lines of text. Let me start with it.

1. Reply to Review 1

According to Review 1, the article is “*not appropriate for publication in [xxxx] for 2 major reasons*: (1) it *reinvents a rather defunct bicycle* [sic!]HH, which was already proposed by Marantz 1984 and Levin 1984 and was rather quickly discarded due to its explanatory inadequacy.”

Even if it were true that Marantz & Levin proposed something that the reviewer apprehends as a “rather defunct bicycle”, the hurried reviewer has neglected his duty and not attempted to apprehend the grammatical situation described in the submitted paper. It neither deals with bicycles nor does it re-invent anything previously proposed, except for re-emphasising the basic insight that the ergative is definitely not the grammatical subject case of a sentence under genuine ergative alignment, as pointed out already in Haider (1986), based on Haider (1985), and in Haider (2000). In the article, the idea is progressed theoretically and grounded empirically.

Forty years ago, Marantz and Levin had attempted to compress the characteristics of ergative languages into the narrow confines of a grammatical theory that was closely modelled on the grammar of English (see footnote 1 of the reviewed paper). However, arguments with an ergative alignment are not suitable for *direct* comparison with English on the basis of a theory developed for English and similar languages: A *morphologically* identified absolutive of an ergative alignment system cannot be *immediately* modelled like a *structurally* identified

¹ The letter from the editor mentions *three* reviews, but I received only *two*. So, I assume these are the negative reviews, one of which is the decisive one. URL of the submitted paper: [<https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/009800>].

grammatical subject of a language like English.² Therefore, it is not surprising that this did not work out satisfactorily. Nevertheless, in both cases, there is a “grammatically privileged argument” aka “grammatical subject” with joint grammatical properties – the absolutive on the one hand and the preverbal argument in the [NP [V XP]] structure of English clauses on the other hand. But, they do not share *every* grammatical property, of course. They are implemented differently, with different collateral properties in each case. As expected, direct extrapolations from the grammar of English to the grammar of an ergative language often fail.

I definitely did not try to “reinvent” a “rather defunct bicycle” but I do want to re-emphasise the *alignment concept* I published in a condensed version in Haider (1986), which is still justified, in an updated and perfected form: For *systems with dependent case*, there are – in principle – *two* ways of implementing a subject function, namely by abs-erg alignment or by nom-acc alignment. It is important to note that nominative-accusative alignment goes far beyond what the grammar of English illustrates. English represents a special case, namely an entirely *positional* system in a *phrase-structural* implementation of nom-acc-alignment. The much more frequent implementation modes are morphological case systems, with morphological case-marking in a *relational* system of cases.

Another droll statement is the following: “*What has become increasingly evident since those early proposals by Marantz and Levin is that no two ergative languages are alike, and proposing a macroparametric solution for all ergative languages is like proposing a cure for all cancers.*” In fact, the reviewer has lost her/his ‘alignment’ even in two places here. First of all, it is a triviality that it has “*become increasingly evident*” that no language – and certainly not English – could serve as a universal model language, and that – in fact – *no two languages are alike*.³ But, if no two (ergative) languages are alike, why do we continue to use the category “ergative languages?” Evidently, these languages must be alike in a relevant aspect that characterises this subset of grammars of human languages. What they have in common, if identified properly, is the particular *alignment mode* in their grammars, and its corollaries, as shown in the paper.

However, what is too often overlooked and disregarded is the following. Not every language classified as an ‘ergative language’ in the specialist literature meets the criteria for a language with an ergative alignment of a grammatical *subject*. In some cases, even the minimum requirements for ergativity ascriptions are not met. A minimal requirement is as follows (and as described in the paper): There must be a *grammatically* privileged argument in a relational system with *dependent case*. Grammars *without* agreement, dependent-case relations, or diatheses do not define a grammatical subject. Their grammar does without this grammatical function. So, such a language cannot be sincerely used as a source of evidence or counter-evidence for claims concerning languages that define a grammatical subject (contrary to Review 2, on Shipibo).

² This is also true for nom-acc languages such as German. See Haider (2010) for details. In English, there is a unique *position* for a subject. In languages with morphological coding, there is a unique *case* (viz. nominative or absolutive) which is not confined to a single position (see VP-internal nominatives in German and Dutch).

³ No two human beings are fully identical either, not even identical twins. Even though identical (= monozygotic) twins start from the same single fertilised egg, differences develop over time. This is true for languages and their grammar systems too; see Latin and its daughter languages. Nevertheless, all humans belong to the same species and share the constitutive properties (viz. “grammar”) of this species, regardless of a multitude of variable and different properties.

The second orientation failure is the failure to distinguish between the individual characteristics of a *language* and the supra-individual properties of the *grammatical system* of that language. In the paper, I am talking about types of grammatical *alignment systems*, and not about each and every individual and idiosyncratic property of a given *language*. The article is an article on ergative *alignment systems* and not a claim on universal *phenomenological* properties of ergative languages. Most languages have grammatical inconsistencies, even though almost all of their grammatical subsystems may function perfectly. Every abs-erg *language* has its idiosyncratic properties and so does each nom-acc language as well. But not *all* properties are idiosyncratic, as we know. The interesting question is whether there are grammatical subsystems that function in the same way in different languages.

The scientifically relevant answer is “yes” and the paper discusses this fact under the heading “alignment modes.” Could this have completely escaped the hasty reviewer's notice? What would such inquiries have in common with “*a cure for all cancers*”? The reviewer apparently loves to resort to rhetorical exaggerations. There are many idiosyncratic properties in every language, but the issue that matters is this: If a language has a *grammatically defined subject function*, this will show in the grammar of the language, and the syntactic properties will be included in the set of grammatical properties of *grammatical* subjects in general.

The second main reason for the rejection of the paper, as given in Review 1, is as follows: “(2) *There is barely any actual data, and the paper fails to engage with the rather extensive literature on ergativity and subjecthood that has been published in the last decade*”. True! Unfortunately, the reviewer does not disclose *what* specific data is missing and which aspects of the literature would affect the claims made in this article. It helps to try to think outside the box.⁴ I could easily copy and paste the references section of recently published work on any topic and prefix it with “*see*” in order to emphasise that a submitted work pays attention to all details and is inside the mainstream. But what would that prove? This paper is not intended to serve as an encyclopaedic article on the trials and tribulations of the research on ergative languages. It analyses the empirically testable consequences of alignment systems.

What has escaped the reviewer's limited attention is that the article arrives at a comprehensive interpretation of the grammatical organisation of ergative alignment systems, which resolves alleged grammatical anomalies in ergative languages, such as the so-called SVO gap, just to mention one example. In a negligent review, a paper is rejected without any attempt to prove the allegations against it to be justified. Without providing any details, it is nothing more than an anonymous, unfounded expression of opinion. I hesitate to express my gratitude in any way for this kind of labour-saving reviewing. I understand that the reviewer does not like the overall direction of the article and wanted to piece together his text as quickly as possible. It would be fairer to save time and energy in advance and refrain from writing a sloppy review. Or is this perhaps just an AI-generated review anyway?

2. Reply to Review 2

Review 2 is a well-argued, seven-page review, and I am grateful for the extensive feedback I received from it. It is a review that attempts to understand the thesis the paper defends and

⁴ “Our understanding of the world is achieved more effectively by conceptual improvements than by discovery of new facts.” Mayr (1982: 23).

challenge it with counter-evidence and counter-arguments. I particularly appreciate the direct confrontation with data from the Shipibo language. I can understand the final verdict of the reviewer, but only when I put myself in her/his shoes. But these shoes don't match the reviewed article, as I will try to make clear.

Let me start with a few objections before entering the Shipibo argument. First of all, the review presents a fine example of a widespread problem of data assessment. Ergative languages are most often documented and described by highly dedicated field linguists. Problems may go unnoticed when data from grammatical descriptions of languages that have not yet been extensively studied are used as a basis for a theory discussion. Such data may still be underexplored and imperfectly analysed.⁵ This can even be the case for languages that are not considered to be under-researched. Here is an example.

Renowned typological surveys such as WALS cannot be trusted unconditionally due to their sometimes-unreliable data basis. Here is an example from word-order typology. With respect to word order typing, Ukrainian is classified as SVO (Feature 81A) and so is Russian. Belorussian, however, is classified as “no dominant order” (Feature 84A). This distinction clearly constitutes misinformation.⁶ In terms of their grammatical properties, these three languages are at least as similar as Dutch and German, Norwegian and Swedish, or even Portuguese and Brazilian Portuguese.⁷ For each of the three Slavic languages, the classification refers to a single reference grammar, and only Mayo’s grammar of Belorussian correctly differentiates *between* syntactic word order freedom and its *discourse-pragmatic* partitioning. The grammar adduced for Ukrainian (by Stechishin) and Russian (by Bivon) confound syntactic and pragmatic order effects. If reviewers rely on this type categories they can turn down any paper on [S[VO]] languages by (wrongly) referring to counterevidence from Russian or Ukrainian. This an example from the field of well-studied languages. The situation with regard to less well-studied languages is certainly no better.

Most descriptive grammars are ‘noisy’. The high level of complexity of grammars makes it impossible to grasp the underlying principles straight away. This calls for patient teamwork. In grammar theory, it is therefore considered taboo to introduce data from any language – no matter how unusual – into the discussion without demonstrating how its analysis supports or challenges a theoretical thesis under debate. Here is an example from Review 2: “*The diagnostics listed in table 1 are hardly universal across ergative languages: there are examples of ergative languages with passives and accusative languages with antipassives.*”

⁵ The more competent the author is, the more realistic and humbler (s)he is: “*I am well aware of the many gaps and shortcomings of the present study.*” Valenzuela (2003: 77), in her 1029-page dissertation on Shipibo.

⁶ “*Apart from the location of clitics there are virtually no syntactic constraints on the ordering of phrases in main declarative clauses. Thus, in each of the Slavic languages all twenty-four possible combinations of a subject, direct object, indirect object and verb occur as grammatical declarative orders.*” Siewierska & Uhliřová (2010:109)

⁷ “*Belarusian and Russian are genetically very close and structurally very similar languages. [...] The structural distance between Belarusian and Russian is of the kind prototypically acknowledged for different dialects of one language.*” (Hentschel 2014: 93-94). Word order is arguably the area of greatest structural convergence between Russian and Ukrainian. Both rely on the same discourse-driven flexibility, facilitated by case, rather than on fixed syntactic positions. Exactly the same is true for Belorussian; see See Haider & Szucsich (2022a,b) for details.

This is a typical but underinformed reaction of *functionalist* typologists. Had the reviewer appreciated Section 2.4 (“Grammatically signalled omission”), (s)he could not mean this seriously. What is sloppily named “antipassive in nom-acc-languages” is no grammatical *diathesis*. It is a collective term for a “varied” collection of constructions that are similar in terms of their communicative effect. These phenomena are highly restricted⁸ and grammatically unrelated to one another in nom-acc languages. The umbrella term refers to any kind of phenomenon that involves a direct object that is apparently omitted, but with no grammatical resemblance to antipassives of ergative languages except for the elimination of a direct object in various kinds of highly restricted contexts.⁹ The point that matters is this: Nom-acc languages with an antipassive *diathesis* (‘antipassive voice’) are unknown and the reviewed paper explains why they do not exist. The converse is true for ergative languages. No grammar of an ergative language defines passive voice; see the definition of passive and antipassive voice in the reviewed paper.

Let me repeat once more that in passive/antipassive *diatheses*, a would-be *subject argument* is grammatically blocked and the argument with dependent case switches into the default case, that is, acc-to-nom or erg-to-abs. In no language, neither abs-erg nor nom-acc, “antipassive” would trigger “nom-to-acc” or abs-to-erg, but ‘ergativists’ are happy with a diagnosis of antipassive, even if – in their grammatical world – an ergative ‘subject’ switches into the form of an absolutive ‘object’, as a kind of spontaneous subject-to-object demotion. It doesn’t upset me if others are happy with irrational ideas, but it does upset me when I’m criticised for not agreeing with grammatical absurdities. These should be set aside for individuals with limited judgment regarding grammatical theory.

The field-linguistic and typological literature contains much noise generated by inadequately analysed data, the grammatical characterisation of which cannot be accepted without further scrutiny. Here is an example that plays an important role in the review and is highly instructive in addition. I am very grateful to the reviewer, who is evidently an expert on the Shipibo language and adduces it as a model language for the discussion, although, as will become clear, it is in fact not a model language for ergative alignment. The properties listed in Table 1 of the papers, that is, properties of grammatical subjects in truly ergative languages, are confronted with data from Shipibo. No wonder that they do not or not fully match.

The reviewer notes obvious divergences and concludes “*The conclusion seems to be that Table 1 is not well-supported by this particular ergative language. And examples like this could be multiplied. But the current paper seems largely oblivious to the issues that this raises.*”

My answer is simple. Shipibo data are highly interesting but not relevant since this language does not have the kind of grammar the paper deals with: It does not define a case system with dependent case. Shipibo has only a marker for a *single* core argument per clause, no case-based agreement system, and no diatheses (passive/antipassive). It is a *differential-marked-subject* language (see below).

⁸ “*The antipassive alternation is often lexically specified and is rather limited in terms of verbs it can occur with (Polinsky 2017).*” Witzlack-Makarevich (2019: 23).

⁹ This is a poor level of abstraction. Even though zebras look like small, striped horses and donkeys look like long-eared, single-coloured zebras, statements about horses cannot be refuted by reference to zebras and donkeys. But typologists seem to expect comparative syntax to accept such data as counter-evidence. In certain areas of functionalist typology, the understanding of *comparative grammar* research seems to be disadvantageously basic.

Here is the reviewer’s juxtaposition of Shipibo data with Table 1 of the paper in blue fonts, together with some comments by me, in black. For the relevant grammatical background on Shipibo please consult section 3 below.

“Shipibo is very uniform and canonical as an ergative language when it comes to case morphology on the arguments of a verb (i.e., it is not a split ergative language in any sense). It can thus be used as a kind of “new” test of the conventional wisdom about ergative languages that has emerged. Here is a brief account of how it works for the 10 properties of Table 1 (plus one).”

- Unmarked case is absolutive: yes, very clearly.

In Shipibo, a clause may contain *numerous* unmarked (aka “absolutive”) core arguments. This clearly indicates that an unmarked argument cannot be the privileged argument in a Shipibo clause. It is not even a case form. It is the absence of case. Shipibo has no system with dependent cases. There is no inflectional case system for core arguments. They remain unmarked except for the suffixal marking of a *single* core argument per clause. Table 1 lists *subject* properties. The Shipibo ‘absolutives’ are not grammatical subjects.

- Agreement is with the absolutive: no. The language has [optional]_{HH} agreement with third person plural only. This agreement is with the conventional thematic subject: i.e. with the absolutive argument of an intransitive verbs and the ergative argument of a transitive verbs – never with the absolutive argument of a transitive verb.

Shipibo verbs do not agree with a subject based on person (1st, 2nd, or 3rd), nor do they mark gender. The verb has only one primary ‘agreement’ marker, namely *-kan*, which *optionally* indicates that the argument it coreferences is plural. In addition, it has *tripartite* adjunct cross-referencing. Adjuncts – such as adverbs, temporal phrases, and secondary predicates – combine with suffixes to indicate the core noun they are modifying or oriented toward, with different suffixes for the *agent* argument and the *undergoer* argument of transitive verbs, and yet another form for the *single argument* of an intransitive verb. This is a *tripartite* coding pattern. There is *no privileged argument* and no promotion contexts.

- Shipibo has “unspecified object” constructions, very much like English. It is the theme argument that is omitted, and existentially quantified over. (Interestingly, the agent argument retains ergative case—unlike e.g. Greenlandic—suggesting that the null theme argument is still grammatically represented somehow.) The ergative argument can be pro-dropped in the right discourse context, but is not especially optional/ “dispensable”.

Theme arguments of transitive verbs are no grammatical subjects in Shipibo. So they may be dropped (see above: unmarked ‘case’). On the other hand, the agent marker is present and remains unchanged, if the undergoer argument is syntactically omitted but semantically interpreted. Evidently, there is no case-dependency relation.

- Shipibo does not have grammatical voice constructions (other than a reflexive/middle voice, if one wants to count that) – neither antipassive or passive.

This confirms that there is no dependent case (that is related to a subject case).

- There is no productive way to ‘promote’ an NP with ergative case (i.e. a transitive subject) so that it has absolutive case.

This follows from the above property, viz. no dependent case.

- When a transitive verb is causativised, Shipibo does have two absolutive nominals: both the causee and the underlying object are absolutive, while the causer is ergative. This contrary to what the author says about grammatical priority (subjecthood) of the absolutive. (Applicatives do work as the author describes, with the base argument of the intransitive verb root receiving ergative and the applied argument receiving absolutive.

First, this clearly shows that the ‘absolutive’ NPs cannot be regarded as noun phrases with (default) case. Second, in such a language, caseless NPs are obviously not subjects. The case rule works straightforwardly. The marking of the highest-ranked argument switches to the causer argument, as expected for a grammar that marks the highest-ranked argument per clause.

- Shipibo does not restrict the extraction of the ergative argument, e.g. in relative clauses. Both ergatives and absolutives can become the head of a relative clause. (Wh words are in situ.)

This fits well since accessibility is a variable property across languages. What is important is this: If in a given ergative language, *only one* grammatical function is accessible, this is the subject.

- Shipibo does not have accessibility advancements (such as antipassive; see also above)

This indicates the absence of case-dependencies.

- Pro-drop in Shipibo is not very well understood. The language does not have rich agreement in person-number-gender of the sort that is expected to license this.

It has no agreement at all for person or gender, and none for singular vs. plural, only an optional plural marker, namely “-kan”, which optionally indicates that the argument it co-references is plural; see Valenzuela (1997:33). The suffix “-kan” coreferences with whichever argument is *structurally highest*, and this is not the “the absolutive” of a transitive verb.

- Shipibo is a fairly ordinary S-O-V language (in conventional terms), with some possibility of scrambling/reordering. In particular, it is clearly not an Abs-Erg-Verb language (what might be mistaken for a O-S-V language), as an extension of the author’s reasoning might suggest (see below).

This is exactly what is expected. In SOV-language, there is a pragmatic agent-first preference which goes parallel with nominative-first in nom-acc languages. In ergative languages, agent-first and absolutive-first are freely available. Syntactically, Shipibo is a free word-order language with respect to the relative order of nominal core arguments, even in the absence of case-marking.¹⁰

Nowhere did I claim that ergative verb-final clauses are OSV-clauses. “Abs-erg-V” is a valid word order variant alongside “Erg-abs-V.” But, if languages that are filed as OSV-languages in surveys such as WALS are genuine ergative languages, that is abs-erg-V languages with genuine ergative alignment. Therefore, their syntactically correct categorization in SOV.

¹⁰ This is not surprising. South-Slavic languages (Bulgarian, Macedonian) are caseless but show the same word order freedom as all other Slavic languages. See Haider & Szucsich (2022a,b) for details.

- Finally, considering other matters that go beyond Table 1, the language has a rich system of switch-reference (reference-tracking), which marks whether or not a designated argument of an embedded clause is coreferential with a designated argument of the matrix clause. In this case, both instances of “designated argument” are the traditional subject (ergative or absolutive, depending on the transitivity of the clause)—not the absolutive argument. It seems like which nominal behaves as the “pivot” for the switch-reference marking system could be classified as a form of being a “privileged core argument”. But if so, then the privileged core argument is not the absolutive in this case. More generally, it is thought that switch-reference does not behave differently in ergative languages from how it works in accusative languages (Austin 1981) (see also Foley & Van Valin 1984).

As the term “switch-reference” suggests, it is a pragmatic property of referencing that is independent of the alignment mode of the given language. It works without grammatically defined subjects [“designated arguments;” see Haider (1985)] since it signals the (non-)identity of two arguments, each of which is the highest ranked argument in the argument structure of the respective verb in each clause.

Let's now briefly re-consider the line of reasoning presented here. At first glance, everything seems straightforward. Shipibo is regarded as an ergative language and it does not meet the criteria listed in Table 1 of the article. And besides, there could very well be many more languages like this. So, the thesis put forward in the paper must be wrong, mustn't it?

And here is my corrective response. I would immediately give up and declare myself lectured and my idea refuted if Shipibo were indeed a language the submitted paper has to deal with – namely, an ergative language with a system of argument identification featuring dependent case relations and a *grammatical subject* function defined by a system of alignment. However, this is clearly not the case.

Not all languages that typologists file as “ergative” are grammatically ergative languages. The typological categories are far too coarse-grained. Shipibo is not grammatically ergative. The folk-linguistic term “ergative languages” is imprecise and not sufficiently distinctive.¹¹ The alleged counterevidence from Shipibo is no counterevidence, as will be explained in the following subsection, viz. Section 3. It goes without saying that data from languages that are not *morpho-syntactically* ergative are not valid data for refuting theories about genuine, *morpho-syntactically* ergative languages.

The Shipibo-argument turns out to be an example of the proverbial mixing of apples and oranges. The article explicitly defines the concept of ergative alignment and emphasises furthermore that the ‘abs-erg’ and ‘nom-acc’ systems do *not* classify and partition human languages exhaustively. Crucially, there are languages the grammars of which do not define grammatical subjects in terms of *alignment* in a *system of dependent case*. Shipibo is such a case. It is a language without a case *system*. It does not define dependency relations between cases because there are no cases for core arguments except a single suffix for the single highest-ranked

¹¹ Here is a biological illustration: Data from whale sharks (*Rhincodon typus*), deep-sea whalefish (*Cetomimidae*), or whale catfish (*Cetopsidae*) would not be accepted as counterevidence for statements about whales (*Cetaceae*), even though all these species bear a *strong external resemblance* to one another. Whales are mammals; the others are fish. Not everything that looks like a whale is actually a whale and the same goes for ergative languages.

argument. Grammatical properties of such languages are irrelevant for the assessment of claims on ergatively-aligned grammatical *subjects*, that is, of abs-erg languages with *dependent case*. Here are the relevant details.

3. Some remarks on the grammar of Shipibo

Shipibo (aka Shipibo-Conibo, a Panoan language of the Peruvian Amazon) features an exceptionally parsimonious way of identifying core arguments. This language consistently marks only a single core argument per clause and it allows only a single morphologically marked core argument per clause. This is the highest argument in the argument grid. Every other core argument, *no matter how many there are*, remains unmarked. There's no dative or oblique case that appears just because a clause has three or four participants. In other words, it lacks a morphological case system. Consequently, there is no marking for the argument of a verb with a single argument.

In studies of the grammar of this language – see the work of Pilar Valenzuela – the marked NP of a multivalent verb is called ergative and *all* the unmarked noun phrases of a Shipibo verb are referred to as absolutive. This is an understandable but misleading way of describing the argument tracking scheme of a language like Shipibo, but it meets the description of “*Ergative: case inflection marking transitive subject (A). Absolutive: case inflection marking intransitive subject (S) and transitive object (O)*.” [Glossary of Dixon (2010 vol. 2)]. In Shipibo, there is no “case inflection” for core arguments, except the suffixal marker for the single “privileged core argument.” As a logical consequence – and not because of a rule governing case assignment – all other core arguments happen to be “treated equally,” meaning they remain without any case marking and do not enter any dependency relation with the marked argument.

One *essential* prerequisite is missing in the surfacy characterization of Shipibo as an ergative language. In order to follow the rule-of-thumb classification for ergativity, the language must have a case *system* with *dependent case*. Shipibo does not have one. It has no passive or anti-passive which would show the direction of case dependencies, nor any other ‘promotion’ contexts. There is a *single rule* of argument flagging:

✧ If a clause contains more than one core argument,¹² mark a single argument – namely, the one that ranks highest in the (cross-linguistically universal) hierarchy of argument structure.

In a nutshell, Shipibo is a *differential marked-subject* language. “Differential” means that the label is used solely for disambiguation, that is, in clauses with more than a single core argument. A marked-subject language is one where it's only the subject that receives the overt case marker, while the objects are unmarked. Its counterpart is a *marked-object language* such as Quechua (e.g. Cusco/Southern Quechua, with O marked by *-ta*). Neither language has a passive or anti-passive diathesis. Marking applies only if there is more than one core argument. All other core arguments are caseless.

The only reason why Shipibo is classified as an ergative language is the superficial application of the rule-of-thumb for ergativity spotting. But something essential is missing. Unlike in *grammatically ergative languages*, the “absolutive” in Shipibo cannot be regarded as a “case” since

¹² This is in perfect accordance with Gibson's (1998) *Dependency Locality Theory*. A fixed prominent argument ('subject') gives the parser a stable "attachment site" it can commit to early and keep active..

all arguments of a verb (which correspond to the direct and indirect objects as well as the objects in applicative constructions) except the single marked one remain caseless. Describing them as “absolutives” suggests the presence of a case system that does not actually exist. There is no ‘assignment’ interaction. It is misleading to regard such arguments as arguments “marked” for an (absolutive) case.¹³ They are unmarked and play no role in case management. They are not in any case-dependency relation with other arguments.

Shipibo is a good example of a language that, at first glance, resembles an ergative language but is not itself an ergative language because it lacks an alignment system. As for core arguments, only in cases of ambiguity – that is, in clauses with more than one argument – one argument is flagged. The ‘flag’ is the suffix “-n” and its allomorphic variants. However, the very same morphological flag is also used as an indication that a noun phrase is *not* a core argument, that is, for adnominal genitive, instrumental, locative, and other oblique functions; see Valenzuela (2003). The overarching generalisation is that the suffix functions as an „elsewhere” marker, signalling that the argument is *not a lower-ranked core argument*, being either the highest-ranking core-argument or no core-argument at all. It is not a dedicated case marker and a fortiori no syntactic ergative marker.

In the following example (i) from Valenzuela (1997: 83), there are two unmarked NPs (“ABS”) and two different cases of “ergative” [-n]-markings on pronouns in a single clause with causative and applicative suffixation on the verb. The agentive causer argument is the highest-ranking argument of the predicate. Hence, it is marked. The possessive pronoun is no argument of the noun in the noun phrase, and it is marked, too. In each case, the marker signals that the marked NP is *no lower-ranked core-argument*. It is either the *highest core argument* or a noun (phrase) that is *no core argument* of the verbal head of the clause at all.

- (i) E-n-ra mi-n bake mi-a nonti a-ma-xon-ke.
 1-ERG-EV 2-GEN child:ABS 2-ABS canoe:ABS do.T-CAUS-BEN-CMPL
 ‘On your behalf I made your son construct a canoe.’ (Valenzuela 1997)

The commonly used term “ergative case” does not do justice to the variety of functions of “-n” in Shipibo and mistakenly overestimates it as an independent syntactic ergative, thereby simultaneously overestimating it as the grammatical landmark of an ergative language. This is the grammatical situation and this is the reason why Shipibo does not match the properties of Table 1. It is a language whose grammar differs fundamentally from that of undisputable ergative languages with grammars that define an alignment system.

Nevertheless, I am *very grateful* to the reviewer for bringing up the case of the Shipibo language. This broadens the perspective on “fake” attributions of ergativity. Not everything that resembles patterns known from ergative languages is actually a language with ergative alignment and Shipibo shows this most clearly. It also shows a way how a language may look like that could have developed into a language with an ergative grammar. If it had, Shipibo would

¹³ Dare not justify this with English as a counter-example! It is true that English has no morphological case marking of nouns and noun phrases, but it has an equivalent, namely positional linking. In an SVO language like English, the grammatical functions of NPs are identified by their position in phrase structure. Shipibo is an SOV language with the word order freedom of SOV languages. There is no positional identification: “*There does not seem to exist any morpho-syntactic difference between the two objects; both are marked absolutive, they can exchange word order without changing the meaning of the clause*” (Valenzuela 1997: 153).

be the proto-ergative onset. It starts out by marking the highest argument in the argument structure and develops either into a system with a case-dependent ergative, and a default absolutive (i.e. abs-erg) or into a system with marked nominative (i.e. nom-acc).

Finally, and interestingly, neither of the two reviewers appreciated the straightforward treatment of causative and applicative constructions, nor seem they have been impressed by the fact that the problem of “no ergative SVO languages” and the problem of OVS languages disappear without a trace, and that real “ergative subjects” need no longer be regarded as strange candidates for a grammatical subject relation, unlike ergatives.

Apparently, most reviewers see themselves as “gatekeepers”¹⁴ and are therefore focused on uncovering an article’s suspected dark sides, while underestimating its ‘bright’ sides. But what if the reviewer is wrong?¹⁵ Then, what is bright appears dark, and the darkness of their own prejudices seems as clear as broad daylight. In any case, the approach taken by the reviewers is understandable if one wishes to avoid having to revise mistaken – yet all-too-familiar – textbook maxims on ergativity. I have to live with that kind of attitude, but I can’t agree with it.

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¹⁴ Scientific peer-reviewing is known for its satisfactorily low *false-positive* rate but also for an alarmingly *high false-negative rate*, namely up to 90%; see the Peters & Ceci study (<https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X00011183>): Of 9 already published articles that were re-entered into a review process under different names without being caught, 8 were rejected – mostly on alleged “*serious methodological flaws*,” despite having already passed review and appeared before in those same journals. Lord, protect us from our protectors!

¹⁵ This may be the effect of a confirmation bias: People who believe in an insufficiently developed theory often steadfastly ignore counterevidence, which makes the job of correcting wrong assumptions proportionally harder.

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